



Glass half full: For the women's hockey team, 2023 was a less-than-fruitful year, but one that saw it end at sixth in the world, its best-ever return since the rankings were introduced. PTI

finished ninth, clearly indicating a need to re-look at the development process of a feeder line. The next six months will be all about working towards the biggest prize in the sport — the Olympics. While the men have their spot sealed as they dream of ending up on the podium yet again, hopefully with a change of medal colour, the women will have to get past the qualifying block first before firming up any plans for the coming months. How things pan out in Ranchi will not just decide the team's schedule for the next few months but also its very core — the future of coach Janneke Schopman and quite a few of the senior players will depend on India

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ensuring a Paris ticket. It won't be easy, though.

While on paper, India is the second-highest-ranked side — only former champion Germany is ranked higher at fifth — teams like New Zealand, the USA, and Italy will be no pushovers. Last time, India barely managed to edge past the USA (with Schopman on the other side) in the qualifiers. Playing at home will be a huge advantage, but India will still need to give its best with a young team and the absence of several experienced players.

None of the challenges on the field are insurmountable, though, provided things remain in order. The recent bribery allegations in Hockey India, questions and pressure on team management, and a general air of gradually slipping into the dangerous bygone days will be the biggest concern for a sport that has, in recent times, been applauded for the best administrative practices. Any deviation from that will be the biggest blow for Indian hockey. Then again, it will be on par with its roller-coaster image.